6.1 INTRODUCTION

Child Health Nursing is aimed to provide the highest possible state of health to each child. It includes preventing diseases or injuries, helping children to meet their health needs, to achieve and maintain adequate health and development. The role of the paediatric nurse depends on her education, experience, job structure and professional demands. The child care depends on the understanding of the parent about the growth and development of the child.

The goal of the paediatric nursing is to faster the growth and development of the children and promote an optimum state of health physically, mentally and socially, so that they may function at the peak of their capacity.

6.2 GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT

Growth is an increase in the size of the whole body or any of its part. It can be measured in inches, centimetres, pounds or kilograms. Development is functional maturation. It is a progressive increase in skills and capacity of function. Each child has its own rate of physical, social, emotional and spiritual growth and development. All children grow through the normal sequence of development.

6.2.1 Factors influencing Growth and Development

1. **Heredity:** The characteristics are transmitted through genes that are responsible for size, shape of the body and also the family illness.
2. **Race:** Similar physical characteristics are seen in people belonging to the same race.
3. **Sex:** A male baby is larger than female
4. **Intra uterine development:** Maternal and nutritional deficiencies, drugs and infections during pregnancy can have effect on the growing foetus.
5. **Illness and injury:** Illness may reduce the weight and minimise the child's process.
6. **Nutrition:** Quality and quantity of food consumed by the child have effect on his/her body building and resistance.
7. **Environment:** Sunshine, air, socio economic factors also affect children's development.
8. **Ordinal position in the family:** Younger children learn from older, which may be lacked by the first child.
9. **Emotions:** Lack of love, security, and parent child attachment can affect the personality. The disturbed children are always slow in development.
10. **Intelligence:** It influences motor development, Psycho social development and learning ability.
11. **Exercise:** Stimulates physical and muscular activity.
12. **Hormones:** Plays an important role in growth and development. E.g. deficiency of growth hormone causes dwarfism and over production leads to gigantism.

6.2.2 Growth Periods

1. New born – From birth to four weeks.
2. Infant – from birth to one year.
3. Toddler – from one year to three years.
4. Preschooler – from three years to six years.
5. Schoolage – from six to twelve years.

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